



MASSACHUSETTS

Department of Elementary
and Secondary Education

*Release of Spring 2026
MCAS Test Items from the
Grade 8 Civics
Paper-Based Test*

**Spring 2026
Massachusetts Department of
Elementary and Secondary Education**

Grade 8 Civics

State Performance Task

This session contains 11 questions.

Directions

Read each question carefully and then answer it as well as you can. You must record all answers in this Test & Answer Booklet.

For some questions, you will mark your answers by filling in the circles in your Test & Answer Booklet. Make sure you darken the circles completely. Do not make any marks outside of the circles. If you need to change an answer, be sure to erase your first answer completely.

Some questions will ask you to write a response. Write your response in the space provided. Only responses written within the provided space will be scored.

The following performance task focuses on the political institutions of the U.S. government.

- 1** The three branches of the U.S. government are shown in the diagram. Different positions in the branches include chief justice, senator, and president.

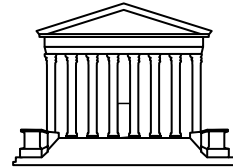
Legislative



Executive



Judicial



The chief justice is a part of the

- Ⓐ executive branch.
- Ⓑ judicial branch.
- Ⓒ legislative branch.

A senator is a part of the

- Ⓐ executive branch.
- Ⓑ judicial branch.
- Ⓒ legislative branch.

The president is a part of the

- Ⓐ executive branch.
- Ⓑ judicial branch.
- Ⓒ legislative branch.

Read and examine the source. Then answer questions 2–4.

The following text describes the U.S. Department of the Interior.

The Department of the Interior is a federal agency responsible for managing and protecting the nation's natural resources. The agency was established by an act of Congress in 1849 to preserve lands for the public to enjoy.

In 2021, the U.S. Senate voted 51 to 40 to confirm Deb Haaland as Secretary of the Interior. She became the first Native American to serve in that position. The photograph shows Secretary Haaland speaking at Yellowstone National Park.



Courtesy of the National Park Service

Part of the Secretary of the Interior's role is to ensure that rules and regulations related to public lands are being enforced. During her visit to Yellowstone National Park, Secretary Haaland stated, "Nature is essential to the health, well-being, and prosperity of every family and community in America. . . . [N]ow is the time to make the investments in our lands and waters that are long overdue." The Department of the Interior's budget for 2021 was \$12.8 billion dollars. Secretary Haaland used a portion of this budget to maintain national parks.

- 2** Which branch of government is the Secretary of the Interior a member of?
- Ⓐ executive
 - Ⓑ judicial
 - Ⓒ legislative

Which of the following is a responsibility of the Secretary of the Interior?

- Ⓐ reviewing civil cases
- Ⓑ advising the president
- Ⓒ commanding the military

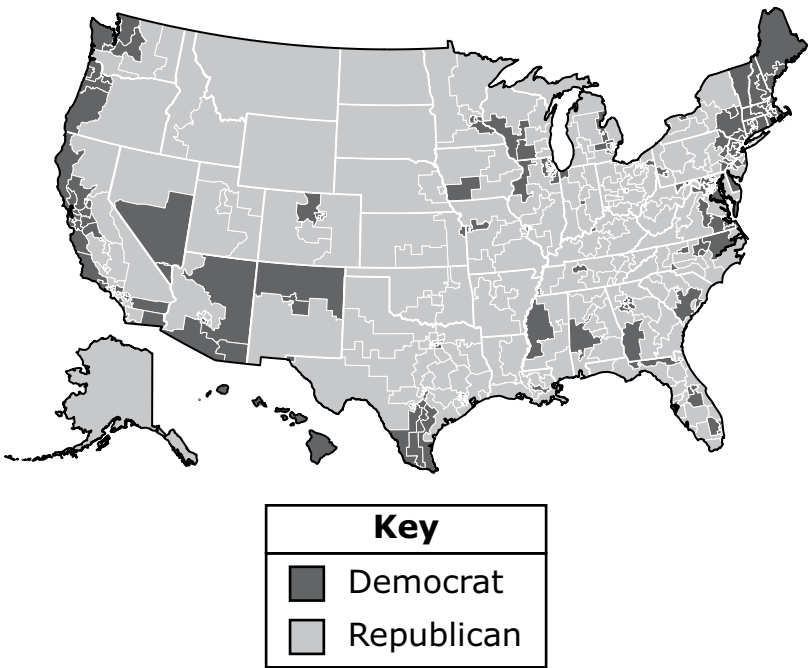
- 3** Based on the source, which of the following **best** describes the role Congress had in creating the Department of the Interior?
- Ⓐ Congress managed tourism.
 - Ⓑ Congress passed legislation.
 - Ⓒ Congress made a court decision.
 - Ⓓ Congress appointed cabinet members.

- 4** Based on the source, describe one way the legislative branch can check the power of the executive branch. Be sure to include information from the source in your response.

Read and examine the source. Then answer questions 5–7.

In the 2020 elections, 222 Democrats and 213 Republicans were elected to the U.S. House of Representatives. The map shows the distribution of members of the U.S. House of Representatives across the United States by political party.

Map of Congressional Districts



Note: There are additional non-voting representatives in the U.S. House of Representatives, including members from Puerto Rico and Washington, DC.

- 5 Which of the following **best** explains how political parties help elect candidates to the U.S. House of Representatives?
- Ⓐ by raising campaign funds for candidates
 - Ⓑ by establishing new voting processes for candidates
 - Ⓒ by passing laws to lower the minimum age of candidates
 - Ⓓ by collecting taxes that pay for the expenses of candidates
- 6 Which of the following **best** explains why a map showing the distribution of U.S. Senators would be different from the map shown in the source?
- Ⓐ Senators can serve only two terms.
 - Ⓑ Senators represent voters from multiple states.
 - Ⓒ Voters from each state elect senators every four years.
 - Ⓓ Voters from each state are represented by two senators.

7 Two students each make a claim based on the map.

Student 1’s claim: There should have been more Republicans than Democrats in the U.S. House of Representatives following the 2020 elections.

Student 2’s claim: Even though Republican representatives were distributed over a larger area of the United States, there were more Democratic representatives in the House following the 2020 elections.

Student 2’s claim is correct.

Using your knowledge of civics, explain one reason student 2’s claim is correct.

Read and examine the sources. Then answer questions 8–10.

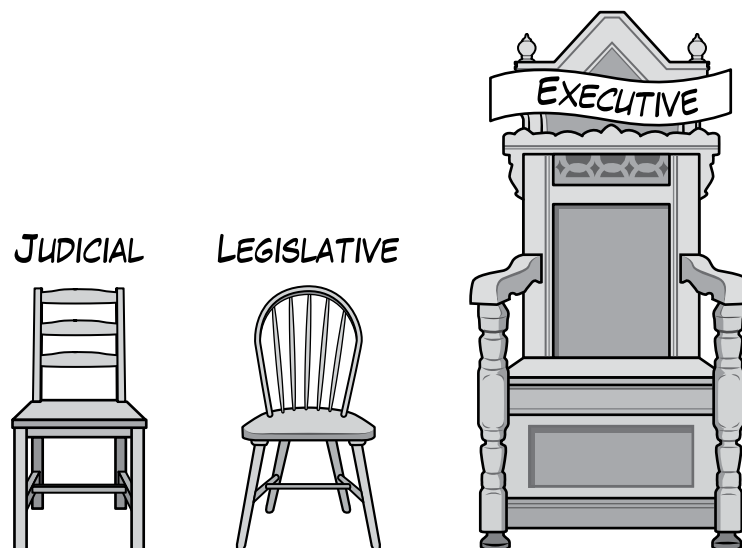
Source 1

The U.S. Constitution describes the roles of the three branches of the federal government. Over time, changes have been made to the Constitution by adding amendments. Summaries of two amendments are shown.

Amendment	Summary
16th Amendment	Congress is allowed to collect taxes on people's incomes.
22nd Amendment	A person cannot be elected to the office of President more than two times.

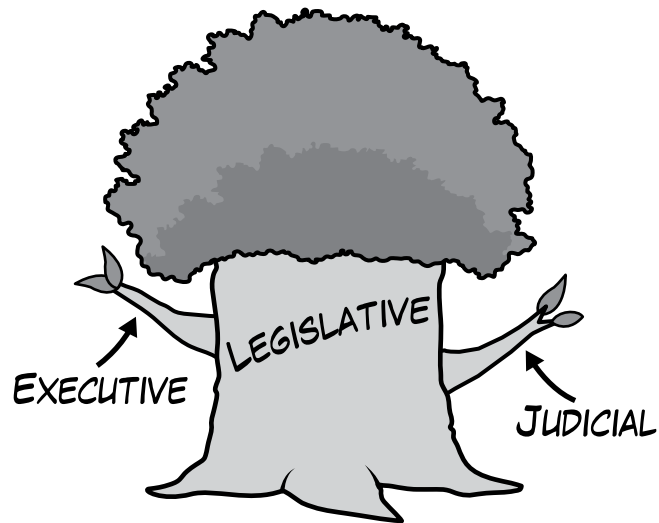
Source 2

A political cartoon about the three branches of the federal government is shown.



Source 3

Another political cartoon about the three branches of the federal government is shown.



- 8** Which of the following did the passage of the 16th Amendment most likely expand?
- Ⓐ judicial powers
 - Ⓑ legislative authority
 - Ⓒ individual protections
 - Ⓓ the president's influence
- 9** Which of the following is the most likely reason the 22nd Amendment was passed?
- Ⓐ to limit the influence of the Electoral College
 - Ⓑ to limit the influence of the executive branch
 - Ⓒ to limit the number of individuals in Congress
 - Ⓓ to limit the number of transitions between presidents

10 A student claims that Congress is the most powerful part of the federal government.

Identify which source, Source 2 or Source 3, shows the political cartoon that best supports the student’s claim. Explain your reasoning.

This question has four parts. Write your response on page 17. Be sure to label each part of your response.

- 11** Franklin D. Roosevelt was president of the United States from 1933–1945. The following photograph shows President Roosevelt giving a speech on the radio.



Courtesy of Library of Congress

In 1933, the law known as the National Industrial Recovery Act (NIRA) was passed, which allowed President Roosevelt to decide how much American workers would be paid at private companies. Many business owners thought the law was unfair and that the federal government had too much power. They challenged the law in the court system. In 1935, the Supreme Court ruled that the law was unconstitutional.

After the Supreme Court declared NIRA unconstitutional, President Roosevelt stated, "During the past half century the balance of power between the three great branches of the federal government has been tipped out of balance. . . ." To help restore the balance of power, President Roosevelt proposed a law to increase the number of justices on the Supreme Court. This new law would have allowed the appointment of a new Supreme Court justice for every justice that was more than 70 years old. The proposed law was rejected by Congress.

- A. Which part of government did President Roosevelt think had too much power?
Mark your answer by filling in the appropriate circle on the next page.
- A** the judicial branch
 - B** the executive branch
 - C** the Department of Labor
 - D** the House of Representatives
- B. Explain why President Roosevelt thought the part of government you identified in Part A had too much power. Use evidence from the source to support your answer.
- C. Determine whether President Roosevelt was able to tip the balance of power. Explain your reasoning using information from the source.
- D. Using your knowledge of civics, describe one way that a president can check the power of the part of government you identified in Part A.

11

A. ☒ the judicial branch

ⓑ the executive branch

© the Department of Labor

④ the House of Representatives

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Grade 8 Civics

Spring 2026 Released Operational Items

PBT Item No.	Page No.	Reporting Category	Standard	HSS Practice Standard	Item Type*	Item Description	Correct Answer**
1	4	<i>Government Structures</i>	8.T3.3	<i>Civic Knowledge</i>	SR	Use a diagram to determine which positions are part of each of the three branches of government.	B;C;A
2	6	<i>Government Structures</i>	8.T3.2	<i>Civic Knowledge</i>	SR	Describe the role of the Cabinet using information from a source.	A;B
3	6	<i>Government Structures</i>	8.T3.3	<i>Analyzing Sources</i>	SR	Determine a role of the U.S. Congress using information from a source.	B
4	7	<i>Government Structures</i>	8.T3.2	<i>Explanations and Reasoning</i>	CR	Use evidence from a source to describe how one branch of government can check the power of another branch of government.	
5	9	<i>Government Structures</i>	8.T3.5	<i>Explanations and Reasoning</i>	SR	Describe how political parties help elect candidates in Congressional elections.	A
6	9	<i>Government Structures</i>	8.T3.4	<i>Explanations and Reasoning</i>	SR	Analyze a map to explain one difference between the U.S. House of Representatives and the U.S. Senate.	D
7	10	<i>Government Structures</i>	8.T3.4	<i>Explanations and Reasoning</i>	CR	Evaluate a claim about the distribution of Republicans and Democrats in the U.S. House of Representatives using evidence from a map.	
8	13	<i>Government Structures</i>	8.T3.2	<i>Analyzing Sources</i>	SR	Determine how an amendment to the U.S. Constitution expanded the power of the legislative branch using information from a source.	B
9	13	<i>Government Structures</i>	8.T3.3	<i>Analyzing Sources</i>	SR	Explain why an amendment to the U.S. Constitution was passed using information from a source.	B
10	14	<i>Government Structures</i>	8.T3.2	<i>Explanations and Reasoning</i>	CR	Analyze two political cartoons and evaluate a claim using evidence from the cartoons.	
11	15–17	<i>Government Structures</i>	8.T3.2	<i>Explanations and Reasoning</i>	CR	Analyze an historical example to describe interactions between the three branches of the U.S. government and explain checks on executive and judicial power.	

* Civics item types are selected-response (SR) and constructed-response (CR).

** Answers are provided here for selected-response items only. Sample responses and scoring guidelines for any constructed-response items will be posted to the Department's website later this year.